

WEDDING CEREMONY SCRIPT ~ JUNE 2026

Please be seated and make yourselves comfortable.

Hello and welcome to you on this very special occasion.

Today, we are here in the fabulous Auld Keep at Dundas Castle,
to witness and celebrate the marriage of Laura and Paul.

Ladies and Gentlemen, Laura and Paul are so proud to share their special day with you.
They would like to thank you for being here. After everything that has happened recently,
it is more important than ever to be together on this happy occasion.
Thank you to all of you, and a special thank you to those who have made the long journey
from London and Leicestershire.

My name is Stephen McLaren, a Celebrant and Marriage Officer with Humanism in Scotland,
a group of Celebrants based here in South Queensferry. It is my honour to be here to conduct
and legally witness Laura and Paul's wedding ceremony. It has been an absolute pleasure to get to
know you as we planned your special day.

Laura and Paul, you have built your life together here in South Queensferry,
so getting married at Dundas Castle is the perfect way to celebrate, and look forward to the next
chapter in your lives. You have been an amazing team for eight years, and today, you promise to
continue to love, cherish and support each other, no matter what.

Ladies and gentlemen, please show your love and appreciation for Laura and Paul
by giving them a round of applause.

Thank you, everyone!

Of course, Laura and Paul deserve all our love on their special day -
but they wouldn't be who they are without YOU, their amazing families and friends.
So today is also a celebration for you, the people who have helped to make
Laura and Paul, the caring, dedicated and brilliant people they are.
Your love, support, friendship and laughter have made all the difference,
so they thank you for everything you have done for them over the years.

A tribute to parents

Ladies and Gentlemen, Laura and Paul are so grateful to you all;
and they would also like to pay tribute, and give special thanks, to their parents:
To Laura's dad, Joe, and her mum, Val;
and to Paul's Mum, Mable, his stepdad James, and his dad, Frank.

Over the years, you have shown your children the meaning of family, commitment and true love.
Thank you for giving Laura and Paul a safe and happy home and the confidence to follow their hearts.
From this day forward, they promise to be the best husband and wife they can be,
with you as their guides and inspiration. Laura and Paul love you.

COMMUNAL BLESSING

Ladies and Gentlemen, because you are so important to Laura and Paul,
they ask if you would bless their marriage, so if you are willing, as I am sure you are,
please answer this communal blessing by saying "Aye, we do!"

**Do you, Laura and Paul's wonderful family and friends,
bless their marriage today with your happiness and love?**

AYE, WE DO!

**And, because he would love to spend an evening with you, eating snacks and watching his
favourite films, do you promise to dog sit for Odin, every now and then?**

AYE, WE DO!

(Odin's favourite movies are Lassie, Scooby Doo and Turner and Hooch.)

Thank you, everyone!

LOVE STORY

Falling in love is a magical thing because it can happen anywhere and at any time.
When two people are ready to go on an exciting new journey, their lives will never be the same.
So, how did Laura and Paul meet? Where did your love story begin?

There came a point when Laura was ready to give up meeting the man of her dreams online - but miraculously, she kept the app on her phone for a few more days so that her friends Becky and Jenny could have fun going on the app when they visited Laura that weekend.

Laura was in Edinburgh for an 8-month work placement, and the algorithms did the rest. As the two friends had fun looking at the lonely hearts of Edinburgh, a few miles away, Laura's profile appeared on Paul's phone.

Paul liked Laura's profile. He liked her smile. So he sent Laura a message.

All this, because Laura's friends were messing around on Laura's phone!

The fine margins between a pot noodle for one and a romantic dinner for two!

Paul was a catch. He was a fireman, and there were dogs in his profile picture.

For the record, the dogs weren't Paul's. They were his mum's!

Laura was 'scunnered', as we like to say in Scotland, after her previous online experiences, so even a dog-loving fireman couldn't change her mind - but Becky and Jenny persisted.

They convinced Laura to send Paul a message.

The spark was instant, and a week later, you went on your first date.

Paul sat near the entrance of the pub, and Laura's feet appeared first as she walked down the stairs.

She had nice feet, thought Paul. With every step, Laura came into view, and suddenly,

Paul saw your smile, and he was a goner! The date was perfect. You chatted and laughed, and both felt happy and relaxed. The voices in your heads were in perfect harmony.

They were singing the song of love!

On your second date, you went for fish and chips in Anstruther.

It's a lovely drive from Edinburgh to the East Neuk, but an hour and a half later,

Laura was starting to think, "This is a long way to go for a fish supper... maybe I'm being abducted."

Laura's only source of comfort was the fact that there was a book about insects and birds in the glove compartment. He must be a nice guy if he likes insects and birds, Laura thought.

It didn't occur to her that maybe Paul was the kind of person who puts pins into butterflies.

Oh well, if Laura was being kidnapped, at least she was getting her dinner first.

On the way back, Laura joked with her potential captor, "I thought I was getting abducted!"

Paul replied, "I've got a shovel and some lime in the back of the car."

Without warning, Laura was introduced to a fireman's sense of humour!

Laura decided to impress her boyfriend with a nice bolognese.

Paul looked on in horror while Laura threw all the ingredients into the pot and turned on the heat.

Thankfully, Laura knew to cook the spaghetti in a separate pan.

"I knew that," said Laura, "but I chucked the pasta into the pot with everything else at the end."
Viola! Laura had made a one-pot bolognese! Perfect for students and camping in the rain.
Not so good on the third date. Paul, also trying to impress, said nothing and politely ate his meal.
Despite clearly not knowing what she was doing, Paul was impressed. Laura didn't panic or fuss when making the meal. She just got on with it and was quite proud of herself.

In September 2019, Paul gave Laura a romantic birthday gift.
It was a Pandora charm with a key, and he asked Laura if she wanted to move in.
You moved in in November and enjoyed your first Christmas together.
Then you went to Budapest in the new year. It was 2020, and you remember hearing the news about covid starting in China. By the spring, Laura was working from home while Paul relaxed and enjoyed the unexpected 'break'. You went into Falkirk station, but there was less work to do, so overall, you quite enjoyed lockdown.

You decided to get a dog, but it was almost impossible with the demand so high.
Eventually, you found a Labrador pup in November, and Odin moved in in early 2021.
Odin has the most gentle, loving spirit I have ever seen in a dog. He has a beautiful soul, just like his mum and dad. You really enjoy living in South Queensferry, and love walking around Dalmeny with Odin. Paul rustles up fabulous meals, a massive relief for you both! Moroccan chicken, two-pot bolognese and, it gets better – Paul loves making cocktails!
Laura, I think you are marrying the perfect man!

Let's talk about the proposal.
Who thinks it's a good idea to take a girl who can't ski to the Alps and propose halfway up a mountain?

Paul did the honourable thing and took Laura to Hillend for a few lessons - very considerate of him. Day one of the holiday was a quick skiing lesson for beginners, and anyone who had never watched Ski Sunday. Laura was both of these things.

Day two was the proposal, and everything was going well.
You were gliding down the slope when Paul started to slow down so he could propose with the Matterhorn in the distance. Then, there was a terrible scream. When Paul turned around, Laura was lying crumpled in a heap.

The ligaments in your left knee had snapped.
You later found out it would have cost £8000 to get a helicopter off the mountain.

It took an hour and a half to get back, and after an agonising ride on the chair lift, a doctor strapped Laura's knee together with Velcro. He told her to get an MRI scan when she got home and sent her away with painkillers and a pair of crutches.

Never mind Laura's leg! Paul's proposal was ruined!

The Michelin Star fondue restaurant Paul had booked was also a bust.

Neither of you was in the mood for chatter and cheese - probably the only time you can ever say that. You went instead for some surprisingly delicious burgers, then you limped back to the hotel to try and get some sleep.

Not surprisingly, day three involved alcohol. The engagement ring was still hiding in Paul's pocket, and Laura wondered why he refused to take his jacket off all day.

On day four, Laura was able to ride on the chair lift, so you headed up the mountain to enjoy the view. Standing next to the toy-town train that carries people up the mountain, Paul proposed while delighted passengers looked on. Laura dropped her crutches and fell into Paul's arms. Literally. Two years later, Laura's knee has fully recovered, just in time for her first tango with her husband later on tonight!

So that was the part of the story that Laura and Paul know, and now, we will hear the part they don't know yet! I asked Paul and Laura some questions recently, and they sent back their answers in secret.

Would you like to hear what you said about each other now?

Choose three words to describe your partner.

Paul, these are Laura's words for you:

Paul is gorgeous; resting-grumpy-face; and funny.

(Sorry, I know the middle one is three words in itself!)

Laura, Paul's three words for you are:

Resourceful, Empathetic, Genuine

What makes you such a great team?

Paul, you said this:

I think we're a great team because our personalities complement each other.

Where I'm prone to charging in head-first, Laura has taught me restraint.

When Laura is being indecisive, I can help focus her mind.

Where one of us struggles, the other is strong. We both have a mutual love of sleeping.

We joke that it's one of our favourite things to do together.

Laura, you said this:

We're a great team because our individual weaknesses are the other person's strengths.

We help one another with their shortfalls instead of making them feel bad for them.

We're always there for one another and always honest (sometimes a bit too honest!)

On a lighter note, Paul always gives me his honest opinion on what I'm wearing BEFORE we leave the house, like when he told me I looked like Arnold Schwarzenegger in Terminator (the full leather outfit)."

"He also always saves me from spiders - I'm petrified of them! Paul is my spider-catching hero!"

Paul will never forget the moment when he knew he was in love:

"I knew very early on that I wanted to spend as much time with Laura as possible.

On maybe our fourth or fifth date, I asked if she'd like to hike up Ben Lomond, near where I grew up.

Laura agreed, and off we went.

The weather was cloudy but dry, but as we climbed, it got wetter and wetter.

By the time we returned after reaching the summit, we were soaked to the skin!

We got warmed up and had some food at a nearby pub, so I asked Laura if she would like to meet my Mum. Without hesitation, Laura agreed. Looking back, a lesser person would have protested about the lack of time to prepare, considering we both looked a tad windswept."

Laura described what she has learned from being with Paul:

"I have learned," said Laura, "that I can be kind, without being accessible to those who don't show me the same kindness.

"I no longer feel the need to prove myself through overgiving, and instead, I feel a steady level of confidence in myself."

And Laura also would like to say this:

"I have always known that I am lucky to have Paul in my life, and I didn't think I could adore him any more than I did. However, over the last couple of weeks, the amount of support, patience, guidance and love he has wrapped around me has only made me admire him more. He is my safe place, and I'm even more grateful that I get to spend the rest of my life with him."

THE INFINITY KNOT

Laura and Paul, you will now exchange vows using traditional handfasting.
Scotland's ancient marriage ritual symbolises love
and the strength that comes from the commitment of marriage.
Together, you are stronger; together, anything is possible.
Your handfasting celebrates all the wonderful things that marriage brings.
I would like to invite Katie to help us with the handfasting, thank you.
And a special thank you to Suzie, who made the wonderful ribbons we are using today.

THE VOWS

Laura and Paul, before you create your infinity knot
please answer your wedding vows in turn, by saying I DO.

**Paul, do you take Laura
to be your lawfully wedded wife,
To have and to hold from this day forward,
For better or worse, for richer or poorer,
In sickness and in health,
To love and to honour 'til death do you part?**

I Do!

**Laura, do you take Paul,
to be your lawfully wedded husband,
To have and to hold from this day forward,
For better or worse, for richer or poorer,
In sickness and in health,
To love and to honour 'til death do you part?**

I Do!

Laura and Paul, please answer the following vow TOGETHER,
by saying WE DO.

**Do you promise to share friendship and laughter
and embrace the adventures and challenges of life, whatever life may bring?**

We Do!

HOLD ON TIGHT TO YOUR RIBBONS, STEP BACK AND PULL!!
EVERYONE CHEERS!

THE RINGS

The wedding ring is a circle; a symbol of eternity and strength, co-operation and peace. Laura and Paul, you will now exchange rings to celebrate your marriage – tokens of love that symbolise the commitment you are making today.

Greig, please present Laura's ring to Paul.

Paul, please take Laura's left hand and repeat these words after me,

I, Paul, take you, Laura, // to be my lawfully wedded wife //

I give you this ring as a symbol of my love.

Paul, you may now place the ring on Laura's finger.

Greig, please present Paul's ring to Laura.

Laura, please take Paul's left hand and repeat these words after me,

I, Laura, take you, Paul, // to be my lawfully wedded husband //

I give you this ring as a symbol of my love.

Laura, you may now place the ring on Paul's finger.

Laura and Paul,

Your rings are a promise to be there for each other,

So walk through life hand in hand, with dedication and love.

In future, when you look at the rings you have shared,

You can remember the love you are feeling today

And together, you can smile.

THE LEGAL DECLARATION

Laura and Paul, I am pleased to report that you have completed the necessary preliminaries for marriage in Scotland, and no objections have been lodged. The legal impediments to marriage have also been explained to you. All that now remains is for you to repeat the necessary declarations before me and in the presence of your witnesses and guests. Please hold hands.

Paul, I turn to you first, (please repeat the following declaration after me.)

I, Paul Simon // solemnly and sincerely declare //
that I know of no legal impediment // to my marrying Laura Brannigan.

Laura, please repeat the following declaration after me,

I, Laura Brannigan // solemnly and sincerely declare //
that I know of no legal impediment // to my marrying Paul Simon.

CAN EVERYBODY PLEASE STAND

Paul and Laura, you have chosen to become husband and wife. You have pledged your love, your respect and your commitment to each other. You have promised to stand by each other through whatever your lives together may bring, and now, following the binding declarations you have made, it is my pleasure and privilege to hereby declare,

That you, Paul, and you, Laura,
ARE NOW HUSBAND AND WIFE!
Paul, YOU MAY NOW KISS YOUR WIFE!

Whoops! Cheers! Applause!!

SIGNING THE DOCUMENT

The guests sit down while we sign the register. Cue the music!

The witnesses are called forward

CLOSING CEREMONY

THE QUAICH

I ask the brothers and Laura's dad to join us for the quaich

Joe will pour the dram

AFTER THE QUAICH

Laura and Paul,

It gives me great pleasure to be able to say these words:

You are now husband and wife!

With patience, trust, and understanding,

and with kindness as your guiding light,

May you bless each other with the love and respect you deserve,

and remain loyal to your family and friends.

If you can do this, love and laughter will always surround you.

Laura and Paul, on behalf of everyone here,

I wish you the very best in your lives together.

Go forward with our happiness and love!

We love you!

CAN EVERYBODY PLEASE STAND

Ladies and Gentlemen, the moment has arrived!

Without further ado, it is my absolute pleasure and privilege

to introduce to you, for the very first time,

The wonderful, happy and newly married

MR AND MRS BRANNIGAN-SIMON!!

Whoops! Cheers! Applause!!

EXIT TO MUSIC